

MARIA SIBYLLA MERIAN

German-born naturalist
and artist • 1647–1717



Maria grew up more than 300 years ago, when the lives of insects were a mystery. Most people believed that creepy-crawlies formed from dirt and rotting waste. They weren't eager to get a closer look! However, 13-year-old Maria was fearless. She roamed gardens collecting caterpillars, which she kept in a crate and watched closely. As they chomped on mulberry leaves and lettuce, Maria was amazed to see the caterpillars fatten up, form cocoons, and finally transform into fluttering silk moths.

Over 50 years, Maria repeated this experiment with hundreds of different insects. She sketched every stage and combined them to create beautiful paintings that showed the transformations. These were some of the very first drawings of the life cycles we learn about today.

Maria painted the
plants that insects eat
and the battles for
survival in nature.

Maria noticed tiny details,
such as the dusty scales
on a butterfly's wings.

